

1914

WORLD WAR I BREAKS OUT

On 28 June 1914, Gavrilo Princip, a Serbian nationalist, assassinated Archduke Franz Ferdinand, heir to the Austrian throne. In retaliation, Austria declared war on Serbia. Existing alliances brought other nations into the conflict. Russia mobilized to help Serbia. Germany declared war on Russia and on France, Russia's ally. German troops invaded Belgium. Britain, committed to defending Belgian neutrality, declared war on Austria and Germany on 4 August. World War I had begun. British, French, and German colonies around the world also joined the war.

▷ Archduke Franz Ferdinand



1912 The South African Native National Congress, forerunner of the African National Congress (ANC), is founded

1913 Russian women celebrate International Women's Day on 8 March; it becomes an annual event

1913 Conflict breaks out between the Balkan League (Greece, Serbia, Montenegro, and Bulgaria) and the Ottoman Empire

1914

1914

ALLIES HALT GERMAN ADVANCE

Intending to knock France out of the war quickly, German forces swept through Belgium and into northeastern France. Instead of encircling Paris, they pursued retreating French forces to the River Marne where, in the first major engagement of the war, the French and British mounted a counter-offensive, pushing the Germans back. Both sides started digging trenches and by Christmas stalemate was reached along a line (the Western Front) stretching from the Belgian coast to the Swiss border.



△ German soldiers in a trench

About 65 million men fought during World War I; some 8.5 million of them died and 21.2 million were wounded